



the basic
idea

does free
will explain
any evil?

A large, solid orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "does free will explain all evil?" is written in white, lowercase, sans-serif font, arranged in three lines.

does free
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1. Some instance of rape, torture, murder, or child abuse is a great evil
 2. There is no good which outweighs this event and which is such that an omnipotent being could not have brought about the good without the tsunami.
 3. A perfectly good being would eliminate every evil unless there was a good which outweighed that evil and it was impossible for that being to eliminate the evil without eliminating the good.
 4. There is no omnipotent and perfectly good being. (1,2,3)
 5. If there is no omnipotent and perfectly good being, God does not exist.
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C. God does not exist. (4,5)

“Traditional free-will approaches - with their move to shift responsibility and/or blame for evil away from God and onto personal creatures - are stalemated by horrendous evil. Human radical vulnerability to horrors cannot have its origin in misused created freedom, because - even if one accepted the story of Adam’s fall as historical (which I do not) - the way it is told, humans were radically vulnerable to horrors from the beginning, even in Eden. The framework within which the primal ancestors made their choices was such that obedient choices meant persistence of the status quo, while disobedient choices would result in the horrendous disarray such as humans have experienced ever since. Even if Adam’s and Eve’s choices are supposed to be somehow self-determined, the fact that the consequences amplify far beyond their capacity to conceive and hence to intend - viz., to horrors of which ex hypothesi they had no prior experience and of which they could therefore have no adequate conception - is not something for which humans are responsible. Rather it is a function of the interaction between human agency and the wider framework within which it is set, and God is responsible for creating human beings in such a framework!”

Surely many events such as these occurred before human beings were on the scene; and surely at least some animal suffering of this kind is an evil.

This gives us the resources to construct a new argument:

The argument from horrific evils

We have now laid out three arguments based, not on the existence of some evil in the world, but based on the existence of particular evils: the evil caused by natural disasters, the evil of pre-human suffering, and especially horrific evils.

2. There is no good which outweighs this event and which is such that an omnipotent being could not have brought about the good without the tsunami.

3. A perfectly good being would eliminate every evil unless there was a good which outweighed that evil and it was impossible for that being to eliminate the evil without eliminating the good.

Each of these arguments relies on the following premise:

One argument against (3) uses the example of a prison sentence. Suppose that someone is justly convicted of a crime, and sentenced to 10 years in prison. Suppose further that this sentence is just.

Now suppose that you are given the chance to reduce the sentence by 1 day. If

the above principle is true, it looks like you should.

But suppose we keep giving you this opportunity. Using the above principle, you will keep reducing the sentence, until it is 0 days in length.

But that seems like the wrong result. Is this a successful reductio of premise (3) of these arguments?

Let's now look at premise (2). One way to object to an instance of (2) is to point to a good which does outweigh the evil and which is such that even God could not have brought about the good without the evil. That's the approach taken by the free will defense.

But that is not the only kind of objection one can make to premise (2) of these arguments. One might also say that, despite the fact that we do not know what good outweighs the evil, we have no particular reason to think that there is not such a good, and hence have no particular reason to think that (2) is true.

Here is one analogy used to support this. Children often have no grasp on the reasons why their parents allow them to experience evil; they cannot see what the greater good is that would justify this.

But the cognitive gap between children and parents is vastly, vastly smaller than the cognitive gap between us and God. So, even if there are goods which outweigh the evils we have discussed, why should we think that we would be able to identify those evils?

The idea is that our **cognitive limitations** are such that we have no reason to be confident that (2) is true, even if it seems true to us. There are two worries about this appeal to our cognitive limitations.

The first is that, if we are this cognitively limited, that would seem to itself be an evil. If there were a perfectly good and all-powerful being, why wouldn't that being give us the resources to see why there is evil in the world?

The second is that it seems to call into question much of our ordinary reasoning about the world. In making decisions about what to do, we often implicitly rely on the assumption that a given decision will not cause untold evils down the road. But if we can be confident of that sort of thing, why not (2)?

Note that the proponent of the free will defense need not choose between the appeal to cognitive limitations and the appeal to the analogy with prison sentences. For example, it may be the appeal to cognitive limitations is more plausible for pre-human natural evils, and the appeal to the analogy with the prison sentence is more plausible in the case of individual horrors.



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Free will can explain some evil; but it can't explain all of the evil we find in the world.

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Summing up so far: we have seen that free will promises to explain how

there could be evil in a world with a omnipotent and perfectly good

God. It can explain that, it seems, if we make the following assumption:

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